

with either Edwin Sydney Vanspaul or Germanpreet Singh.

While the lack of centre-forwards in the national team besides Sunil Chhetri due to inadequate playing time in the ISL has been a long-standing issue, there are also concerns over attacking midfielders being played out of position. If Indian forwards are shifted to the wings to accommodate overseas exports, the central attacking midfielders will then have to fight it out with these Indian forwards for a place in the wings.

Due to the high-stakes environment of the top division league, coaches prefer overseas players over Indians in attacking midfield positions to maximise the threat upfront and minimise risks on the ball.

One of the Indian attacking midfielders, Sahal Abdul Samad, who has long been admired for his dribbling and close control, never really found a regular run as a No. 10 player during his time at Kerala Blasters. There was a perceived risk of him or any other inexperienced Indian losing the ball in the central areas of the pitch and exposing the team to counterattacks.

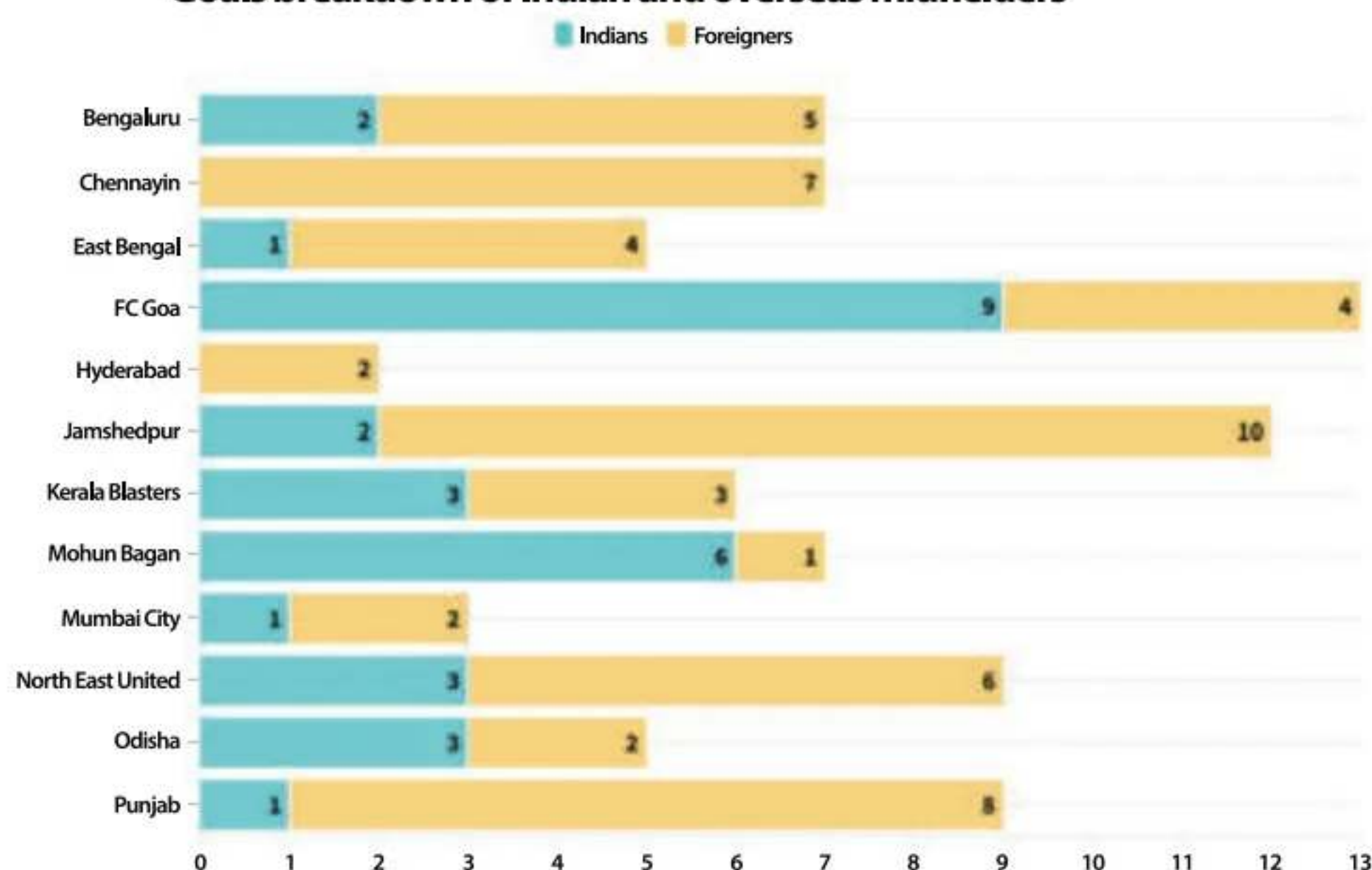
That trend would further add to Stimac's frustration, who urged ISL clubs to play Indians in both centre-forward and attacking midfield positions. "This is the only way," he said in an interview with Hindustan Times in 2023.

Even Brandon had to be shunted to the left flank in favour of overseas attacking midfielders. Thapa, who Coyle described as the 'best Indian midfielder', was played out of position after his move to Mohun Bagan at the start of last season.

Injuries to defensive midfielders meant that Juan Ferrando, former head coach of the Mariners, played Thapa — a box-to-box midfielder — as a lone defensive midfielder, which didn't work out too well.

The difference in playing time for Indian and overseas midfield players is quite lopsided. Among the 64 Indian midfielders who played in the 2023/24 ISL, only 26 completed 800 minutes or more. But among the 24

Goals breakdown of Indian and overseas midfielders



overseas midfielders, 22 played over 800 minutes.

The overseas midfielders bring valuable experience and technical prowess, significantly enhancing goal-scoring output in the final third (see graph). The foreigners have a hand in 105 goals (54 goals and 51 assists), dwarfing the Indians' tally of 66 (31 goals and 35 assists).

At Chennaiyin, a 35-year-old Rafael Crivellaro, who had been out of action through injuries for the better part of 2021 and 2022, finished with four goals and seven assists this season while not even being at his best.

Every ISL team, except perhaps FC Goa, has a key overseas midfielder as the central hub, with an Indian player in a supporting role. The base of Goa's midfield saw Carl McHugh being an ever-present fixture along with Rowllin Borges, Raynier Fernandes, and Ayush Chhetri as his midfield partners, while Brandon was the creative fulcrum in the No. 10 role. At FC Goa, the Indian midfielders outperformed the overseas midfielders in both goals and assists.

In the last seven ISL seasons, as the duration of the league expanded beyond three months, several midfielders have shown

promise, but none have secured a central or attacking midfield position in the national team.

Midfielders like Anirudh Thapa (below), Sahal, Brandon, Lalengmawia, Rowllin, Deepak Tangri, Amarjit Singh Kiyam, Jeakson Singh, and Suresh Singh Wangjam have all been regular faces with the Blue Tigers but with mixed results.

Thapa has been played as a No. 6, a No. 8, and a No. 10 without nailing down a specific position. Sahal, as an attacking midfielder in the No. 10 role, has been influential in the last year, but his output has been underwhelming with just two assists. Amarjit, who was Stimac's preferred central midfielder in 2019, has had his progress derailed by injuries.

Brandon's injuries had kept him out for over 18 months until his return to the national team earlier this year. Tangri, too, has had spells out with injuries, while Lalengmawia fell foul of Stimac last year but has since made a comeback. Suresh, on the other hand, has been woefully out of sorts in recent years.

Among them, Lalengmawia is the only player who possesses a well-rounded game both on and off the ball and can play both as a defensive midfielder and a box-to-box midfielder. At 23, his best years are yet

